Prasad and Mukhopadhaya concede that India failed to convince the non-Pashtun political elite of its conciliatory intent. According to Mukhaopadhaya, 'it has been an issue of communication … but then they [opposition groups] have legitimate grievances against president Karzai. They feel betrayed and so on. This is not against Pakistan, they want us [India] to fight their battle … I met Mohaqiq the other day and asked him these questions that the government [Karzai] is saying that you guys are going off talking to the Pakistanis and so on. But I can't tell the president politely that please don't try to shoot them [the opposition] off from our [Indian] back'.[97] The only other former UF leader with whom India got along well was Atta Muhammad Noor, the governor of Balkh and Abdullah's staunch ally. An extremely powerful figure, Atta Noor wanted to make Mazar-e-Sharif, the capital of Balkh province, into Afghanistan's Dubai (economically), and did not nurture presidential ambitions unlike other non-Pashtun leaders.

India was unable to help Karzai's opponents in ways they had asked for (supporting them politically and/or financially against Karzai). Instead, Indian diplomats tried convincing Karzai's opponents to accept his presidential authority. This was done right from the 2001 Bonn conference (where Lambah tried convincing Qanooni to give up ministerial berths to Pashtun candidates), till the 2004, 2009, and the 2014 national elections.[98] 'But then president Karzai started marginalising them slowly, and in odd ways. For example, Abdullah was released of his duties [as foreign minister] when he was on a visit to Washington. So there were genuine issues there', says Prasad. India's unfazed support to Karzai regardless of these concerns was simply a measure of New Delhi's focus on strategic outcomes in Afghanistan instead of processes. Karzai's wrongdoings were reconciled with the long-term interest of maintaining India's long-term presence in Afghanistan (tied to Karzai's political fortunes), to ensure that Kabul was a counter-balance to Islamabad, and to secure an internal political balance within Afghanistan. Prasad had many long discussions with Karzai, most of which were never mentioned even in diplomatic cables given how sensitive and unguarded these talks were. He argues that 'in the long term we know that a non-Pashtun candidate may be politically problematic, and that it is important to have a Pashtun as the head of the state'.[99] Narayanan concurred.